CONGRESS MANIFESTOS

NO FAREWELL TO WELFARE

The Congress's poll manifestos are following a distinct pattern. Though Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Telangana are yet to receive their renewed vouchers for the Grand Old Party's gift hampers, we already have a near-complete picture. It's a policy blueprint incubated and evolved in its own laboratories—the states it rules (Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh) or won recently. The party's bouquet of 1,290 promises for Madhya Pradesh and its pledges for Mizoram, both released on October 17, borrows much from those two states. And Telangana is being offered visions similar to Karnataka. The common thread? Of course, its own formula of welfarism. This often comes with an implied or overt critique of 'gaps' in the BJP's central policies (public health, jobs, farm MSPs, pension). And sometimes with equally visible copycat (Hindu appeasement) and competitive strands (women's welfare).



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

MIZORAM

The 12-page manifesto promises to strengthen grassroots democracy

- Reintroduction of the Old Pension Scheme
- Rs 2,000 old-age pension per month
- 100,000 new jobs for the state's youths
- LPG cylinders at Rs 750 for BPL and priority households
- Rs 5 crore annual budgetary provision to assist patients of cancer, other serious ailments
- Health insurance cover of Rs 15 lakh for cashless treatment

TELANGANA/ BRS

FREEBIE FRENZY

The Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) has vowed to widen the scope of its existing welfare schemes in Telangana besides announcing a few new ones. This, even as a slew of sops that Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao has announced since 2018 remain undelivered or just partially fulfilled

By Amarnath K. Menon

NEW PROMISES

- **KCR Bima Prathi Intiki Dhima:** Rs 5 lakh life insurance cover for all BPL families
- **Sowbhagya Lakshmi:** Rs 3,000 a month allowance to women in BPL families
- **KCR Aarogya Raksha:** Threefold hike in health insurance cover for BPL families—from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 15 lakh. Accredited journalists to be eligible too
- **Rythu Bandhu:** Investment support for farmers to go up from Rs 10,000 to Rs 12,000 per year in 2024; Rs 1,000 annual hike thereafter
- **Aasara:** Rs 1,000 hike in monthly social security pension in 2024; to go up by Rs 500 every following year. (At present, it's Rs 2,016 for the elderly, widows, weavers, etc., Rs 4,016 for persons with disabilities)
- **Residential schools:** All 204 residential schools for Muslims, other disadvantaged to be upgraded as degree colleges; 119 schools—one in each assembly segment—to be opened for the poor among savarnas



"KCR has copied our six guarantees. It's not just the state that's bankrupt, even he is... for the want of ideas"

–A. REVANTH REDDY, *Telangana Congress president*